📓 1. “Kindly Adjust to Our English” – *Shashi Tharoor*

🔍 Summary:

This witty and insightful essay defends **Indian English** as a valid and evolving form of the language. Tharoor begins by humorously claiming he invented the word **“prepone”** (opposite of postpone), and uses it to highlight how Indians creatively adapt English to suit their needs.

He argues that just as **American English** has diverged from British English, **Indian English** has developed its own identity — with phrases like “do the needful,” “airdash,” and “mugging” (for studying). He celebrates these as **linguistic innovations**, not mistakes.

However, Tharoor also draws a line: some usages like “return back” or “waive off” are **grammatically incorrect**, not just Indian variations. He ends with a cheeky flourish: “We are like that only. Kindly adjust.”

✨ Key Themes:

- **Linguistic identity**: Indian English reflects Indian culture and creativity.
- **Language evolution**: English is not static; it adapts to local contexts.
- **Pride vs. correctness**: Celebrate Indianisms, but avoid actual grammatical errors.

🧠 Smart Takeaway:

Tharoor’s essay is both a **celebration and a critique** — he urges Indians to take pride in their version of English, while also being aware of what’s truly incorrect.

🚂 2. “A Fellow Traveller” – *A.G. Gardiner*

🔍 Summary:

This charming personal essay narrates a late-night train journey where the author believes he’s alone — until he’s joined by a **mosquito**. What follows is a humorous and philosophical battle between man and insect.

At first, Gardiner tries to kill the mosquito, but it keeps dodging him with ease. Slowly, the mosquito becomes more than a pest — it becomes a **symbol of life**, a **fellow traveller** on the same journey. In the end, Gardiner chooses **mercy over violence**, letting the mosquito live.

✨ Key Themes:

- **Human ego vs. humility**: The mosquito humbles the narrator.
- **Companionship in unexpected places**: Even a mosquito can be a “fellow traveller.”
- **Philosophy of life**: We are all fleeting beings, sharing space and time.

🧠 Smart Takeaway:

Gardiner uses humor to explore **deep truths** — how even the smallest creature can teach us about **compassion, equality, and the mystery of existence**.

🌳 3. “Leisure” – *W.H. Davies*

🔍 Summary:

This short, lyrical poem is a **critique of modern life**. Davies laments that people are so busy chasing material goals that they forget to enjoy the **beauty of nature** — like watching squirrels play or stars twinkle.

The poem begins with the famous lines:

“What is this life if, full of care,

We have no time to stand and stare.”

He argues that a life without time for reflection and nature is **empty and wasted**.

✨ Key Themes:

- **Nature and mindfulness**: True joy lies in observing the world around us.
- **Critique of modernity**: Busyness has robbed us of peace.
- **Simplicity**: Happiness comes from slowing down.

🧠 Smart Takeaway:

Davies reminds us that **leisure is not laziness** — it’s essential for a meaningful life. The poem is a gentle call to **pause, breathe, and appreciate**.

📘 1. *“Kindly Adjust to Our English”* – Shashi Tharoor

📝 Sample Question 1:

Q: How does Shashi Tharoor defend Indian English in his essay “Kindly Adjust to Our English”?

Answer: Shashi Tharoor defends Indian English by presenting it as a vibrant, evolving form of the language that reflects India’s cultural identity. He argues that just as American English has diverged from British norms, Indian English has developed its own unique expressions like “prepone,” “do the needful,” and “airdash.” These are not errors but creative adaptations that serve practical communication needs.

Tharoor emphasizes that language is shaped by usage, and if millions of Indians use these terms daily, they deserve legitimacy. He also highlights how Indian English incorporates local sensibilities — such as calling elders "uncle" or "auntie" — and even translates cultural phrases like "good name." However, he draws a line between creative usage and grammatical mistakes, criticizing redundancies like "return back" and incorrect phrases like "waive off."

Ultimately, Tharoor's tone is witty and assertive. He celebrates Indian English as a living language and ends with a humorous call to "kindly adjust," urging readers to embrace linguistic diversity with pride.

🚂 2. *"A Fellow Traveller"* – A.G. Gardiner

📝 Sample Question 2:

Q: In "A Fellow Traveller," how does Gardiner use humor and reflection to convey a deeper message?

Answer: A.G. Gardiner's essay "A Fellow Traveller" begins as a humorous account of a man battling a mosquito during a train journey. Initially, the narrator is annoyed and tries to kill the insect, but the mosquito's agility and persistence turn the situation into a comical chase. Gardiner uses vivid imagery and playful language to describe his failed attempts, making the mosquito seem almost human in its cleverness.

As the essay progresses, the tone shifts from humor to reflection. The mosquito becomes a symbol of life itself — small, fleeting, yet full of vitality. Gardiner begins to see it not as a nuisance but as a fellow mortal sharing the same journey. He chooses mercy over violence, recognizing the shared mystery of existence between man and insect.

Through this transformation, Gardiner explores themes of humility, companionship, and the fleeting nature of life. His essay reminds readers that

even the smallest creature can evoke empathy and philosophical insight, making "A Fellow Traveller" both entertaining and profound.

🌳 3. *"Leisure"* – W.H. Davies

📝 Sample Question 3:

Q: What is the central message of W.H. Davies' poem "Leisure," and how is it conveyed?

Answer: W.H. Davies' poem "Leisure" delivers a powerful critique of modern life's obsession with busyness. The central message is that life loses its meaning when we are too preoccupied to appreciate the beauty around us. Davies laments that people no longer take time to "stand and stare" — to observe nature, enjoy quiet moments, or reflect on life.

The poem uses simple yet evocative imagery: squirrels hiding nuts, stars twinkling, and beauty dancing in nature. These images contrast sharply with the hurried pace of human life. The repetition of the line "We have no time to stand and stare" reinforces the urgency of the poet's plea.

Davies' tone is gentle but critical. He doesn't condemn progress, but he warns that without leisure — without time to pause and connect with nature — life becomes hollow. The poem is a timeless reminder to slow down and find joy in the ordinary.

📓 "Kindly Adjust to Our English" – *Shashi Tharoor*

◇ Q1: What is the significance of the word "prepone" in the essay?

Answer:

Tharoor uses “prepone” to illustrate how Indian English creatively adapts language. He claims to have coined the term as a logical opposite of “postpone,” showing how Indians simplify communication. Its widespread use reflects how Indian English evolves through practicality and usage.

◇ Q2: How does Tharoor differentiate between Indianisms and incorrect English?

Answer:

Tharoor celebrates Indianisms like “do the needful” and “airdash” as culturally rooted expressions. However, he criticizes phrases like “return back” and “waive off” as grammatically incorrect. He argues that creativity is valid, but errors should not be justified as Indian English.

◇ Q3: What is the tone of the essay and how does it support the message?

Answer:

The tone is witty, assertive, and slightly cheeky. Tharoor uses humor and clever examples to defend Indian English while gently correcting common mistakes. This engaging tone helps readers appreciate the richness of Indian English without feeling judged.

🚌 “A Fellow Traveller” – *A.G. Gardiner*

◇ Q1: How does Gardiner transform a mosquito into a symbol of companionship?

Answer:

Initially annoyed, Gardiner tries to kill the mosquito but fails. Over time, he begins to admire its agility and persistence. The mosquito becomes a “fellow traveller,” sharing the same journey and space. This shift reflects Gardiner’s philosophical view of life and empathy.

◇ Q2: What does the essay reveal about human ego and humility?

Answer:

Gardiner’s failed attempts to kill the mosquito expose his ego. As he reflects, he realizes the mosquito is superior in agility and spirit. This humbling experience leads him to mercy, showing that true dignity lies in compassion, not dominance.

◇ Q3: How does Gardiner use humor to convey deeper meaning?

Answer:

The essay is filled with playful descriptions — chasing the mosquito like a matador, imagining courtroom trials. This humor makes the essay entertaining, but also sets the stage for deeper reflections on mortality, companionship, and the shared mystery of life.

🌳 “Leisure” – *W.H. Davies*

◇ Q1: What is the central message of the poem “Leisure”?

Answer:

Davies warns that modern life is too fast-paced, leaving no time to enjoy nature or reflect. He argues that a life without leisure is empty. The poem urges readers to slow down and appreciate simple joys like watching squirrels or stars.

◇ Q2: How does Davies use imagery to support his theme?

Answer:

Davies paints vivid scenes — squirrels hiding nuts, beauty dancing in nature — to show what we miss when we're too busy. These images contrast with the mechanical rush of life, reinforcing the need for mindfulness and presence.

◇ Q3: What poetic devices are used in "Leisure"?

Answer:

Davies uses **rhyme**, **repetition**, and **personification**. The repeated line "We have no time to stand and stare" emphasizes urgency. Nature is personified as "Beauty" who dances — making the poem lyrical and emotionally resonant.